The River

A river journeys from the mountains to the plains. In this poem, the poet describes the river as if it is a person who does different things and has many different moods.

The River's a wanderer,
A nomad, a tramp.
She doesn't choose one place,
To set up her camp.

The River's a winder,
Through valley and hill.
She twists and she turns,
She just cannot be still.

The River's a hoarder,
And she buries down deep
All those little treasures,
She wants to keep.

The River's a baby,
She gurgles and hums.
And sounds like she's happily
Sucking her thumbs.

The River's a singer,
As she dances along.
The countryside echoes
The notes of her song.

Valerie Bloom (b. 1956) was born and grew up in Clarendon, Jamaica. Much of her life and work has been influenced by Caribbean life and culture. Valerie's work first became known when she won a national competition. Later she moved to England where she now lives with her family in Kent. Her work has been published in over 200 anthologies.

nomad: a person who moves from place to place with family and belongings tramp: a person who has no home or job and keeps moving from place to place winder: not straight; with twists and turns hoarder: a person who collects and stores things gurgles: sounds like a baby when it's happy or like water quickly flowing through a narrow space echoes: sends back and repeats the sound

In this section, we will:
- understand the details of the poem.
- learn how to analyse a poem.
(C-2.1, 2.2)

Make connections

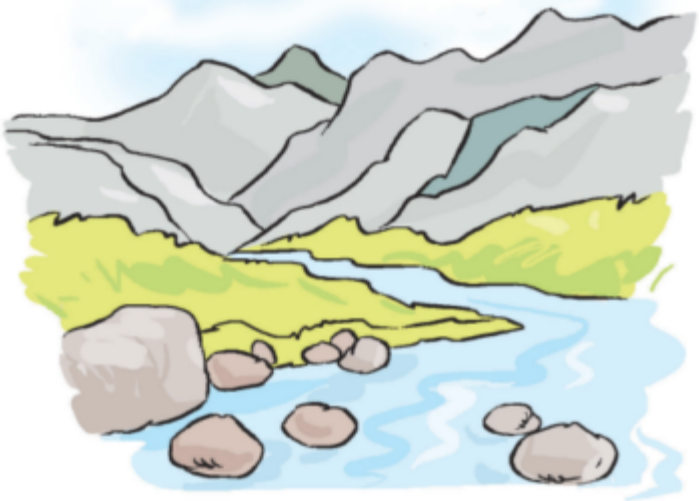
Answer the following questions based on the poem.

1. Read the table headings and write at least five words in each column.

Rhyming word pairs from the poem	Metaphors used to describe the river
.....	.....
.....	.....
.....	.....
.....	.....
.....	.....

2. Read these lines and answer the questions that follow.

   a. *The River's a wanderer,*
   A nomad, a tramp.
   She doesn't choose one place,
   To set up her camp.
   The River's a winder,
   Through valley and hill.
   She twists and she turns,
   She just cannot be still.



      i. Wanderer, nomad, tramp: what do these three words tell us about the river?
      ii. What are the different places that the river flows past in the poem?
      iii. In your own words give the meaning of 'to set up camp'.

   b. *The River's a hoarder,*
   And she buries down deep
   All those little treasures,
   She wants to keep.

      i. Why is the river called a 'hoarder'?
      ii. Which word means 'puts deep inside'?
      iii. What do you think are the treasures that the river wants to keep?

3. Circle the groups of words that describe what the river does not do.

stay still	flow in the countryside	stay in one place	flow silently	give away her treasures

4. Why does the poet call the river a 'singer'?
5. In this poem, many comparisons have been used to describe the river. Think of a river you have seen. Is there anything else you can compare a river to?

Appreciation

In this section, we will:
- learn about sound words and compose a poem using sound words. (C-3.3, 4.1, 4.2)

Sound words

1. The poet describes the sounds the river makes. The river 'hums', 'gurgles', 'sings' and 'sounds like she is sucking her thumbs'. Here are a few lines in which we describe the sounds that water makes. Read these lines aloud.

a. The rock fell into the pond with a loud splash.

b. I emptied the pot and let fresh water gurgle into it.

c. The calm water softly lapped the shores of the lake.

d. The huge waves crashed against the rocks on the seashore.

e. The heavy rain drummed down on my roof.

f. I could hear the pitter-patter of the gentle rain.

Arrange these sounds from the softest to the loudest.

2. Here are a few lines from a poem called 'Sounds of a School Morning' by Shefali Martins. Read the lines aloud and circle the sound words.

The clock chimes in the hall to tell us it's six o'clock,
The click of the door says Grandma is going for a walk.
Busy little sparrows twitter on the neem tree,
Pots and pans clang as breakfast is made for me.
Then beep-honk-beep calls the school bus horn,
We make a line and then, turn by turn, get on.
At school everybody is full of laughter and chatter,
As long as we are polite, a little noise does not matter.
And then we get alert as the school bell goes ding-dong,
The assembly starts and we proudly sing our school song.
We walk briskly to our classes and now we are quiet,
Except for our shoes that patter—left, right, left, right.

3. What are the sounds that you can hear on the playground? Write five sentences with these sound words and then compose a poem of your own using those words.